stable as the market was volatile. To break this constant uncertainty surrounding the auctions, the company forayed into selling tea in packets, transforming it from a tradable commodity to a consumer-centric product.

As Krishna Kumar told the *Financial Times* in 1997, 'The reason we moved away from selling tea at the auction was to realise the full value for the crop we grow. The focus on consumer marketing has enabled us to maximise the return for stakeholders.'

The Tata veteran was hands-on with Tata Tea. He virtually planned and executed all its important moves and had a blueprint for its growth. His involvement in the company was so deep and pervading that his personal touch was apparent everywhere.

The acquisition of Tetley was not Tata Tea's first foray overseas. Persuaded by Ratan's determination to expand globally, in the early 1990s, the company had acquired a majority stake in Sri Lanka's Watawala plantations. It had also established a subsidiary in Florida. The next logical step was to acquire a big international brand. And Krishna Kumar set his sights on Tetley.

The time was right for the Tatas to gain access to the technology of blending, branding, packaging and the vast distribution network of a bespoke brand. And which company would be better than Tetley, a 163-year-old brand? The future partners were not strangers to each other. They had already been associated since 1992, when they had entered an export JV, creating Tata Tetley. At the time Ratan had seen the opportunity to achieve a synergistic union of the two companies that could yield substantial dividends for Tata Tea.

The First Attempt

Ratan made his first move on Tetley in late 1994 and early 1995. At the time it was the largest beverage manufacturer in the UK and the second-largest in the US. Tetley was especially known for its innovation in the beverages business. Its tea bags had become household staples in the globalized world. Allied Domecq, its owner, was shedding its food operations, including its legacy business in tea, as it had shifted its focus to alcohol.

Ratan was quick to understand that competition for Tata Tea within India would soon grow after liberalization, with global companies setting up shop